

The (digital) dance of democracy



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Last month, just before we closed this issue, all of us from Digit who’re eligible to vote exercised our right to franchise in and around Mumbai. We were happy that we made our voice heard where it matters the most (so to speak), but none walked away satisfactorily from the experience. All of us faced trouble (in varying degrees, of course), from getting registered, to the day of polling and finally pressing that big, bold button on EVMs. Some of our family members’ names were missing (despite having voted in the past and having valid election IDs), others had to hop across centres to find their names. No one checked my ID at my designated polling station, which was shocking to say the least. Clearly, while technology has invaded almost all facets of our online and offline existence, the Election Commission of India hasn’t kept pace with some of the merits of the digital age.

Amidst all this chaos, the city’s voting percentage increased by double digits. I’d like to think that this swell in numbers was contributed to largely by first-time voters afflicted with the romance of casting their inaugural vote, as over 100 million new young voters were added to the electorate this year. The youth have largely kept pace with the “Great Indian Election Tamasha” digitally, particularly bombarded with information through social media. Our political parties and leaders have taken to social media with great vigour, which is a good sign and a great way of engaging the allegedly disenchanted strata of voters into the current political discourse. From political satire (memes, jokes, parodies) to alleged exposés, live Hangouts to Facebook and Twitter debates, the web has been deployed to good effect before and during this Lok Sabha elections.

This embracing of social media and big data analysis will only increase in the future, not just for national elections but even local ones. Opinion polls, which are easy to rig, will be a thing of the past.

A joint report by the Internet and Mobile Association of India (IAMAI) and the Mumbai-based Iris Knowledge Foundation predicts that Facebook users will “wield a tremendous influence” over the results of the polls in 160 of the total 543 constituencies. Even a team of researchers at the Ohio Centre of Excellence in Knowledge-enabled Computing at Wright State University have been tracking the Indian polit-

ical sentiment on the web since July 2013. Don’t treat it as the holy grail, obviously, but some of the data revealed here is quite fascinating. Take a look: <http://dgit.in/2014insights>

However, most of our country’s electorate (over 70 per cent of the 814 million) still live in villages and haven’t even heard of Facebook, Twitter or Google+, let alone use any of these social platforms. For them, smartphones enable access to election-related information (and propaganda) unlike any other – after all there are more mobile phone users in India than toilets, remember? Parties have reached out to them ingeniously. One tool developed by BJP, called Voxta, allows voters to listen in on political speeches in real-time on their phones from anywhere in the country. AAP has signed up thousands of members by only asking people to give them a missed call. All parties have flooded WhatsApp (with 48 million Indian users) to overcome the hurdle of last-mile-connectivity to directly get their message across to eligible voters.

I remain hopeful that all this enabled tech-savvy voters to form a better opinion of their local leaders, political parties, and their national agenda, before making an informed decision and casting their votes. No one has any excuse to not vote anymore, especially with the introduction of the NOTA button to at least “waste” your vote by accounting it to yourself (read more: <http://dgit.in/LigbR7u>). All of us here at Digit would be disappointed if anyone of our readers who was eligible to vote didn’t carry out his or her civic duty.

As for my opening rant against the Election Commission, we know it’s ill-equipped to conduct these elections against overwhelming odds with over 930,000 polling booths, 1.7 million voting machines, and 11 million personnel helping them conduct this democratic exercise. Technology holds the key to alleviating their burden as much as ours (as voters).

Until the next general elections in 2019 then, and the ability to vote remotely or in advance, as per our convenience. Wouldn’t that be a sight for sore eyes, yes? 